

The Impact of AI-Driven Recruitment Systems on Employee Perceptions of Fairness in Hiring Decisions

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A. Proposed Programme of Research

The proposed research programme will be based on the impacts of Artificial Intelligence (AI)-based recruitment systems on employee perceptions of fairness in hiring decisions in contemporary organisations. The choice of this research area is supported by the increasing trend of using algorithmic screening and automated decision making in the recruitment practices rather than relying only on human judgement. Although the benefits of AI technologies are widely reported to enhance efficiency, consistency, and cost-effectiveness, these benefits are disputable in the context of low transparency and a lack of understanding of the decision criteria by the applicants or employees (Ilham, 2025; Naseer et al., 2025). The analysis is thus based on the efficiency of operations, as well as the effects of the AI application in redefining the views of procedural fairness, trust, and organisational legitimacy. This study analyses the conflict between technological decision-making and human control, which forms a basis of systematic literature review and construction of a rigorous research design.

A) Literature Search Methodology & Evaluation

Databases Used

A systematic literature review conducted to identify high-quality scholarly sources that can be used in AI-based recruitment and perceptions of equity in hiring. Different academic databases were used to ensure broad and methodological diversity of references. Scopus, Web of Science, Business Source Complete, Emerald Insight and ScienceDirect were the main databases because they cover a wide range of peer-reviewed studies in the area of Human Resource Management, organisational behaviour and information systems. Google Scholar was used as an additional tool to trace citation networks and discover influential studies that were not initially found in the databases. These databases enhanced the credibility of the search process as it minimised the possibility of publication bias and database specific constraints.

Search Parameters Used

A number of search parameters were used to maximise the relevance and scholarly quality of sources retrieved. Only peer-reviewed journal articles published since 2015 were included in the search as the AI technologies in the recruitment setting are evolving. English language publications only were incorporated to allow accurate interpretation. The subject areas were streamline to Human Resource Management, Management, Information Systems and Organisational Psychology in order to have interdisciplinary relevance and allow recency.

These parameters helped to identify existing research that is methodologically robustness with minimising the inclusion of outdated or irrelevant sources.

Search Terms Used

Keywords associated with Artificial Intelligence, recruitment processes, and fairness perceptions were combined by using Boolean search strategies. Primary search terms included “Artificial Intelligence”, “AI-driven recruitment”, “algorithmic hiring”, and “automated recruitment systems”, reflecting the technological focus of the study. These were integrated with perception-related terms like perceived fairness, procedural justice, algorithmic transparency, and employee perceptions to make them conform to the behavioural aspect of the study. Additional terms including “algorithmic bias”, “hiring fairness”, and “trust in AI decision-making” were used to capture ethical and psychological aspects of recruitment technologies. Systematic application of Boolean operators (AND/OR) was used to narrow down results and reduce irrelevant results. Search terms were refined through iterative refinement as new concepts were identified in the process of review.

Ranking Parameters

Critical assessment of retrieved articles was done based on structured ranking criteria to determine the relevance and methodological strength of the articles. The priority was given to empirical research that focus on the exploration of the AI-driven recruitment systems and their impacts on the perceived fairness or procedural justice. The ranking of studies was based on a number of major criteria which included conceptual relevance to the research focus, methodological transparency, sample adequacy, analytical rigour and clarity of findings. Peer-reviewed journal articles published in high-impact management and HR journals were given a higher priority as they tend to undergo rigorous editorial review processes. Conceptual papers were retained if they offered a background theoretical understanding, especially concerning fairness and decision-making theory. This ranking hierarchical process enhanced the validity of the literature selection process and contributed to the formation of a logical evidence base.

Search Outcomes

1. Kurniawan, A.W. (2025) Candidate experiences in AI-driven recruitment: a phenomenological study on algorithmic bias and fairness perceptions. *Journal Management & Economics Review (JUMPER)*, 2(5), pp. 179–184.

2. Girona, A.E. and Yarger, L. (2024) To impress an algorithm: minoritized applicants' perceptions of fairness in AI hiring systems. In: *International Conference on Information*, April. Cham: Springer Nature Switzerland, pp. 43–61.
3. Naseer, A., Tanveer, M., Imran, M., Siddique, F., Razaq, N. and Haider, H.A. (2025) AI in recruitment and selection: balancing efficiency and fairness in hiring decisions. *Advance Journal of Econometrics and Finance*, 3(4), pp. 95–101.
4. Kulal, A., Dinesh, S. and N, A. (2025) Organizational impact of AI-driven recruitment practices: a mixed methods study. *Journal of Computer Information Systems*, pp. 1–16. Available from <https://doi.org/10.1080/08874417.2025.2508860>
5. Ilham, R. (2025) Examining the effect of algorithmic hiring, perceived fairness, and HR tech literacy on recruitment acceptance. *International Journal of Business, Law, and Education*, 6(1), pp. 834–843.
6. Agbasiere, C.L. and Nze-Igwe, G.R. (2025) Algorithmic fairness in recruitment: designing AI-powered hiring tools to identify and reduce biases in candidate selection. *Path of Science*, 11(4), pp. 5001–5021.
7. Hasanah, I.A. (2025) Ethical implications of AI-driven recruitment: a multi-perspective study on bias and transparency in digital hiring platforms. *Journal of Management and Informatics*, 4(1), pp. 599–616.
8. Majrashi, K. (2025) Employees' perceptions of the fairness of AI-based performance prediction features. *Cogent Business & Management*, 12(1), p. 2456111.
9. Leszczyński, G., Gaczek, P. and Ławrynowicz, M. (2026) The bright side of AI in hiring: collaborating with algorithms supports ethical decision-making. *Journal of Business Research*, 203, p. 115812.
10. Thivnuja, S. (2026) The effectiveness of AI-powered recruitment tools in reducing hiring biases: a data-driven analysis. *Journal of Management Matters*, 12(2).

Summary of Key Conclusions from the Top 5 Articles

Study conducted by Kurniawan (2025) reported that the automated recruitment decisions were perceived to be less transparent particularly in cases where the outcomes were not clearly stated. Demographic differences were also reported, with applicants who were marginalised showing a higher mistrust of AI systems. Thus, the study indicate that perceptions of fairness are quite sensitive to transparency, explainability, and perceived human responsibility and demonstrate the importance of human-oriented governance in the practice of AI recruitment.

Girona, and Yarger (2024) study revealed three important procedural rules; consistency of administration, job-relatedness of selection criteria, and provision of selection information to be important determinants of perceived fairness. The research also revealed that the perception of fairness differed among demographics, and the use of organisational communication determines trust and acceptance of AI-based recruitment systems.

Naseer et al. (2025) performed a cross-sectional study with quantitative research that investigated the relationships between AI recruitment systems and perceptions of fairness. The results showed that efficiency of recruitment was enhanced, but the results of fairness were closely associated with transparency, governance arrangements, and the relationship between human and AI interaction.

Similarly, Kulal et al. (2025) employed a mixed-methods design to evaluate the effects of AI recruitment in organisations and found transparency constraints and algorithmic bias to be current issues. There was a focus on the need of governance structures and accountability mechanisms to enhance employee confidence in the study.

Ilham (2025) used regression analysis to analyse the association between the use of algorithmic hiring, perceived fairness, and recruitment acceptance. The findings revealed that perceived fairness was the most significant predictor of acceptance, and the HR technology literacy enhanced the user knowledge of algorithm systems.

Literature Gap Identification

Despite the recent progress in the understanding of fairness in AI-driven recruitment, there are still critical conceptual and methodological gaps. Qualitative research reported by Kurniawan (2025) and Girona and Yarger (2024) offers an excellent indication of real-life experiences of candidates and raises concerns about the lack of transparency, procedural unfairness, and inequality in the perception of fairness based on demographics. However, these articles largely focused on individual experiences, and provide little analysis of organisational practices influencing perceptions of fairness in operational HR settings. In contrast, the quantitative studies reported Naseer et al. (2025) and Ilham (2025) indicate that there are important correlations between transparency, perceived fairness, and recruitment acceptance, but the cross-sectional design of these investigations limits the ability to understand the dynamics of perception development over time or across recruitment phases. Similarly, Kulal et al. (2025)

identify the importance of governance mechanisms and transparency in mitigating algorithmic bias, but do not isolate the relative effectiveness of specific HR policy interventions. Collectively, these limitations indicate a lack of integrated research combining behavioural perceptions with organisational-level governance and decision-making practices. Thus, it is evident that context-specific research investigating the effect of transparency, accountability, and HR policy implementation on employee perceptions of fairness in AI-based recruitment systems is required.

Section B — Methodological Classification of Top 5 Articles

Study	Geographical Focus	Research Paradigm	Research Design	Data Collection Method	Participant/Subject Characteristics	Sample Method	Sample Size	Analytical Techniques
Kurniawan (2025)	Indonesia (AI recruitment candidates)	Interpretivist	Qualitative (Phenomenological)	In-depth interviews	Job candidates exposed to AI recruitment tools such as resume screening and video interviews	Purposive sampling	20 participants	Thematic analysis
Girona and Yarger (2024)	USA (technology education context)	Interpretivist	Qualitative (Focus groups & interviews)	Focus groups and semi-structured interviews	Women, Black, and Latinx computer science students	Purposive sampling	47 participants	Thematic coding based on procedural justice theory
Naseer et al. (2025)	Pakistan (public and private organisations)	Positivist	Quantitative (Cross-sectional survey)	Structured questionnaire	HR professionals, recruiters, and job applicants with exposure to AI recruitment systems	Purposive sampling	200 participants	Correlation and regression analysis

Kulal et al. (2025)	India (organisational HR settings)	Pragmatist	Mixed-methods	Surveys and semi- structured interviews	HR professionals involved in AI- driven recruitment implementation	Stratified and purposive sampling	Not explicitly stated (mixed sample groups)	Quantitative statistical analysis and qualitative thematic analysis
Ilham (2025)	Indonesia (job applicants)	Positivist	Quantitative (Regression-based study)	Structured questionnaire	Job applicants exposed to algorithmic hiring platforms	Convenience sampling	350 participants	Multiple linear regression analysis

Critical Methodological Evaluation of Selected Studies

The chosen articles represent a methodological diversity in exploring the perception of fairness in AI-based recruitment that indicates the complexity of exploring behavioural and organisational aspects of automated hiring. Qualitative methods used by Kurniawan (2025) and Girona and Yarger (2024) provide insight on candidates' experience of candidates and their perception of fairness, especially regarding the transparency and procedural justice. The studies employ purposive sampling that is reported to be appropriate in selecting participants with direct experience to obtain in-depth contextual data on how they perceive bias and procedural injustice (Ahmad and Wilkins, 2025). The adoption of interpretivism paradigm in these studies offer a considering the subjective experiences and aligns with the procedural theory of justice which emphasises the importance of perceived fairness in developing organisational trust (Ghweidi, 2025). Qualitative research however has limited generalisability and applicability of the results due to relatively small sample sizes involved in qualitative research (Boddy, 2016).

In contrast, the positivist quantitative research in Naseer et al. (2025) and Ilham (2025) allows testing the relationship between fairness perception, transparency, and recruitment acceptance in a statistical approach. These researches employ structured questionnaires, and regression-based analytical approaches to discover predictive relations among fairness variables and behavioural results (Saunders and Lewis, 2023; Telukunta et al., 2025). The larger sample sizes enhance statistical reliability and enhance generalisability of results (Bryman and Bell, 2015) thus, this method is useful in the context of organisational decisions. However, cross-sectional survey designs do not provide the possibility of measuring longitudinal changes in the perception of fairness, especially as workers become accustomed to the AI recruitment technologies. However, quantitative approaches can simplify the psychological reactions to algorithmic decision-making (Bryman, 2016).

The mixed-methods design method adopted by Kulal et al. (2025) represents a pragmatic methodological approach that combines quantitative measurement and qualitative interpretation. This methodology strengthens triangulation of the methodology and helps to validate the results with the help of more than one data source (Bryman and Bell, 2015). The presence of numerical information and background details enhances the explanatory richness and promotes a holistic assessment of organisational behaviours that affect the perception of fairness (Creswell and Clark, 2017). Mixed-methods researches, however, required significant

methodological skills and resource allocation, which may restrict their applicability in smaller research contexts (Creswell and Clark, 2017).

Section C — Reflection on Research Paradigms

Research paradigms are the philosophical basis through which research issues are perceived and researched (Bryman and Bell, 2015). Positivist, interpretivist, and pragmatic paradigms are observable in the research that investigates the perception of fairness in AI-driven recruitment, which affects research design and data analysis. Positivist methods, which Naseer et al. (2025) and Ilham (2025) adopted, focus on being objective and quantitative, by using structured surveys and regression analysis. These researches indicate a positivist epistemology, which presupposes that knowledge may be created based on quantifiable observation, and an objectivist ontology, in which the perception of fairness is discussed as a measurable variable. Although this methodology facilitates generalisable conclusions that can be used in organisational decision-making, it could miss the emotional and socially constructed aspects of fairness that appear in the context of automated hiring (Bryman and Bell, 2015).

The qualitative research of Kurniawan (2025) and Girona and Yarger (2024) where participants use interviews and focus groups to understand the meaning of fairness, bias, and transparency is rather indicative of interpretivist paradigms. These researches are indicative of the subjectivist ontology and interpretivist epistemology, which acknowledge that the perception of fairness is constructed in social interaction and organisational communication. These methods offer richness and contextual understanding of procedural justice experiences, especially in HR settings. Nevertheless, the transferability of the results to other organisational settings might be restricted by the use of smaller purposive samples (Saunders and Lewis, 2023).

Reflecting on my own methodological preferences, I am inclined toward a pragmatic paradigm, as it aligns with the complex and applied nature of fairness perception in AI-driven recruitment. Pragmatism provides a means to combine quantitative and qualitative approaches to consider both objective relationships, such as trust and transparency, and subjective understandings of fairness. The combined-method approach that Kulal et al. (2025) have shown can help in explaining the intensive power of statistical analysis with qualitative data to increase the validity of the research. Epistemologically, I understand that I need to combine objective

measurement with interpretive understanding and ontologically that the perception of fairness is both a perception that is a trend and socially constructed significance. This alignment facilitates methodological adaptability and allows the creation of evidence-based HR approaches that consider behavioural and organisational aspects of fairness (Creswell and Clark, 2017).

Section D: Identifying Future Research

a. Style of Independent Project

The proposed research will be based on a research project format since this type of research is best suited to explore how employees perceive fairness in AI-based recruitment systems. This choice is justified by the fact that the reviewed studies, such as Kurniewan (2025) and Ilham (2025) highlights the necessity to collect empirical data systematically to understand the behavioural responses to algorithmic hiring. A research project will allow to organise the data collected, conduct statistical testing, and theoretical interpretation, which will help to develop evidence-based HR practices. The approach also aligns with the identified literature gaps, specifically, the need to conduct context-specific empirical research, explore the impacts of transparency and organisational governance on the perception of fairness in real organisational conditions.

b. Potential Aims and Objectives

Potential Aim

The aim of this proposed study is to examine how Artificial Intelligence (AI)-driven recruitment systems influence employee perceptions of fairness and to identify organisational factors that enhance transparency and trust in automated hiring decisions.

Potential Objectives

- i. To examine employee perceptions of fairness in AI-driven recruitment systems within organisational settings.
- ii. To investigate the relationship between transparency of AI decision-making processes and perceived procedural fairness.

iii. To evaluate the influence of organisational governance practices on employee trust in AI-supported recruitment.

c. Potential Research Questions

Research Questions

i. How do employees perceive fairness when recruitment decisions are supported by Artificial Intelligence systems?

ii. To what extent does transparency in AI-driven recruitment processes influence perceived procedural fairness?

iii. How do organisational governance practices affect employee trust in AI-based recruitment systems?

d. Project Design

The proposed research will be based on the pragmatic research paradigm because this paradigm allows combining both quantitative and qualitative research to explore the perceptions of fairness in AI-based recruitment systems. Pragmatism is deemed suitable since the literature on the subject reveals the significance of integrating quantifiable with contextual knowledge (Bryman and Bell, 2015). Thus, this study will use a mixed-methods sequential explanatory design, where the quantitative data collection will be preceded by qualitative research to elaborate on the emerging patterns. This design is justified by the fact that perceptions of fairness entail observable behavioural reactions as well as socially constructed interpretations (Hays-Thomas, 2022). The mixed-methods design facilitates the triangulation process and enhances validity of results, which increases the strength of conclusions made based on organisational research (Creswell and Clark, 2017).

e. Methods

The research proposed will be based on a mixed-methods design (a combination of quantitative and qualitative approaches) to investigate employee perceptions of the fairness of AI-based recruitment systems. This approach is justifiable as mixed-methods research enables combining the numerical measurement with the contextual knowledge that enables the analysis

of complex organisational phenomena in more holistic manner (Creswell and Clark, 2017). Quantitative research is useful in establishing statistical relationship between transparency, trust and perceived fairness, as demonstrated by Naseer et al. (2025) and Ilham (2025), while qualitative research by Kurniawan (2025) and Girona and Yarger (2024) reveals that the subjective perception of procedural justice needs to be captured. Combining the two methods promotes triangulation and increases the validity of research since it makes it possible to analyse findings in a variety of contexts (Saunders and Lewis, 2023).

A structured online questionnaire will be used to gather quantitative data, that will be administered in a secure online platform (Qualtrics). Online administration is chosen as it allows distributing efficiently to employees working in different organisational units, anonymity, and elimination of interviewer bias, which increases response accuracy and reliability (Zahrani and Amelia, 2023). The questionnaire will consist of Likert-scale questions that will gauge perceived fairness, transparency, trust, and acceptance of AI recruitment systems, with previously validated constructs to increase reliability and construct validity. The participant information and consent statements will be provided in the survey link which will be administered through organisational email systems.

The qualitative stage will involve the use of semi-structured interviews, which will be performed via the secure video-conferencing systems, including Microsoft Teams or Zoom. This administration method is suitable because it allows scheduling flexibility, facilitates accessibility of participants, and gives probing questions a chance to elucidate answers, thus increasing the depth and credibility of data (Saunders and Lewis, 2023). The semi-structured interviews were chosen because of its applicability in the research of ethical issues, perceived bias, and emotional reactions with regards to automated recruitment procedures (Easter et al., 2022).

The respondents will be a sample of employees who are employed in organisations that use AI-assisted recruitment technologies. To make sure that the subject is represented in all job roles and organisational levels to minimise sampling bias and enhance representativeness, a stratified sampling method will be used. The proposed sample size of 100 participants, as this size reported to be enough sufficient to perform the regression analysis and guarantee statistical validity (Seabrook, 2025). In the qualitative stage, purposive sampling will be used to identify 10 participants who will offer rich qualitative information on their experiences.

Descriptive statistics and regression analysis will be used to analyse quantitative data, which will allow studying the relationships between transparency and trust and fairness perceptions. Thematic analysis will be used to analyse qualitative data and facilitate the organisation of recurrent patterns in the experiences of the participants (Braun and Clarke, 2022).

f. Potential Strengths and Limitations

The suggested mixed-methods research has a number of advantages that justify its appropriateness to explore the perceptions of fairness in AI-based recruitment systems. One of the key strengths is the combination of quantitative and qualitative approaches, which allows triangulation and enhances the overall validity of the results. Structured questionnaires and semi-structured interviews enable the statistical measurement of fairness perceptions as well as a more in-depth insight into employee experiences, which contributes to in-depth knowledge about organisational practices (Creswell and Clark, 2017). In addition, stratified sampling contributes to better representativeness of organisational roles, minimising sampling bias and maximising reliability (Sarker and AL-Muaalemi, 2022). Validated measurement scales are also known to enhance construct validity and promote consistency when interpreting data (Sarker and AL-Muaalemi, 2022). However, there are still a number of limitations. The data collected through self-reported questionnaires can create bias in the response especially where the employees are reluctant to give negative responses. The cross-sectional nature also restricts the ability to study any long-term effects on fairness perception and the qualitative sample is smaller which could limit the generalisation to other organisational contexts (Braun and Clarke, 2022).

Ethical Issues

The ethical issues are critical in conducting research on employee perceptions of AI-based recruitment systems, especially because of the sensitivity of organisational decision-making and personal experiences. One of the main ethical concerns is the informed consent, where the participants are informed about the purpose of the study, the voluntary nature of the participation, and the right to withdraw without penalty. Ethical transparency and autonomy of participants are supported by the provision of a participant information sheet in detail and written or electronic consent to data collection (Zumitzavan, 2026).

Another critical ethical issue is confidentiality and anonymity especially when the participants might have critical views about the organisational recruitment practices. To mitigate this risk, the questionnaire answers will be anonymised and the interview data will be coded to eliminate recognisable information. Participant data will be secured by using the password-protected files and encrypted digital storage that will be used to ensure the protection of data and meet the data protection requirements, including the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR). Confidentiality is important when the research is conducted among employees who may be providing sensitive issues of fairness related to AI technologies.

Moreover, ethical risks may arise with the potential misunderstanding of the responses of the participants, especially in the case of qualitative interviews when the perception of bias and fairness can be emotional or personal. This study will thus, ensure neutral questioning methods and not to guide the participants to a certain direction of answers. Ethical implications also encompass responsible reporting of findings, where the results are reported without exaggeration or misrepresentation. Moreover, ethical approval of the institutional research ethics committee will be sought before data collection and it will be ensured that all the procedures are conducted in accordance with the existing academic and professional standards (Saunders and Lewis, 2023).

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